

you're sending," she said in the video over pretty black-and-white shots of her own wedding.

Maybe so, but you don't have to spend \$2,000 on your wedding dress. You can wear a hand-me-down or rent one or buy one second-hand from places like stillwhite.com or preownedweddingdresses.com. Heck, it can be like Amy Poehler's was on *Parks and Recreation*, entirely made out of newspapers (and Leslie still had a perfect wedding to Ben!).

If you or your partner will be wearing a suit, the suit rental has to be factored in too. The Bridal Association of America estimated the cost of renting the tux at almost \$200 and "groom accessories" (cufflinks, vest, shirt, tie) at \$116. You may also need to pay for a fitting if you're buying a suit, or for pressing and cleaning the tux and a fee for having it overnight if you're renting. CostHelper Weddings said buying a suit could run a partner (they say *groom* but I say *partner*) anywhere from \$300 to \$1,500. My girlfriend works for a suit company that makes bespoke wedding suits for about \$1,500 to \$2,000.

I'm occasionally guilty of sentimentalizing weddings too. On Instagram, I've posted a few times a beautiful photo of my mom and dad kissing over their wedding cake. I compliment the floral crown my mom has in her hair, boasting about how flawless she looks. But more than thirty years later, her version of her wedding is less than glamorous.

In fact, when I last asked her about it, she launched into a story about how my parents originally invited 70 people, but then my father's mom, Meme, wanted to invite 125 more people at the last minute. My parents simply couldn't afford it. The bride's family usually pays for the wedding (How is that still a thing?) and my mom, with her limited resources and only one living parent, freaked out. She didn't have the money. Meme had talked my mom into buying a wedding dress that was \$1,000, which is about \$2,500 now with inflation. (FYI: That's above the average cost of a wedding dress in the United States, which is around \$1,500 currently.) My mom insisted she could have just gone to the sale rack. The wedding kept getting more and more expensive as the things she assumed she could cut back on were deemed "necessary" for her perfect day by other people.